

Elops saurus

Ladyfish

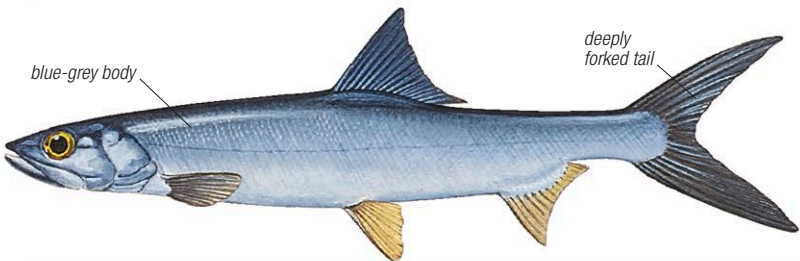


Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight 31 lb (14 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location W. Atlantic, Gulf of Mexico, Central America, Caribbean



Also known as the ten-pounder, this sleek, blue-gray fish is covered with fine scales. It attacks small fishes in schools, and is well known for its habit of skipping along the surface and for leaping when hooked. Adult ladyfishes move out from the coast into open water to spawn in schools; exact locations are not known, but they are believed to spawn up to 100 miles (160 km) offshore. The transparent, eel-like larvae eventually drift or migrate back to inshore waters.



Megalops atlanticus

Tarpon



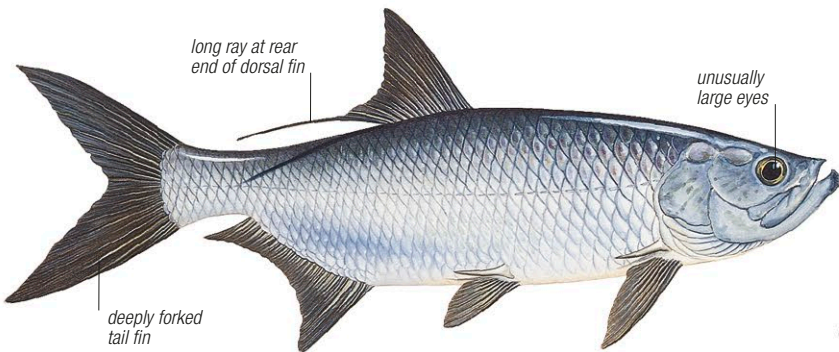
Length ¼–8¼ ft (41.3–2.5 m)
Weight 350 lb (160 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Vulnerable

Location W. and E. Atlantic



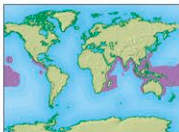
A large and powerful fish, with a deep body and an upturned mouth that extends far beyond the eyes, the tarpon looks like an unusually large herring. It is

found in coastal waters and estuaries, and sometimes also in freshwater, and feeds almost exclusively on schooling fishes such as sardines, anchovies, and mullets. Its lunglike swim bladder enables it to overcome the occasional shortages of oxygen that occur in estuaries and similar kinds of habitat, by breathing air at the surface. It is a popular sport fish, and makes spectacular leaps when hooked. Between late April and August, adult tarpons move into open water to spawn. The transparent, eel-like larvae may be transported for a year or more, ultimately ending up in estuarine nursery grounds, but also frequently occur in pools or lakes disconnected from the sea.



Gymnomuraena zebra

Zebra moray



Length Up to 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight 22 lb (10 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Pacific, Gulf of California, Indian Ocean



Morays are thick-bodied and often powerful eels that typically lurk in clefts in rocks or coral with only their heads

showing. They have no pectoral or pelvic fins. There are 200 species, and many, including the zebra moray, are brightly colored. This snakelike fish has a long, cylindrical, highly muscular body, and a large mouth with blunt and pebblelike teeth, adapted for crushing prey. It usually adopts a lie-and-wait feeding technique, and typically lurks in rock or coral crevices, lunging outward to catch its prey. However, it may occasionally leave its hole at night in search of prey. The zebra moray feeds on large and heavily armored prey, particularly crabs and other crustaceans, found around reefs. There is evidence that it can eat larger crabs than other morays of comparable

Albula vulpes

Bonefish



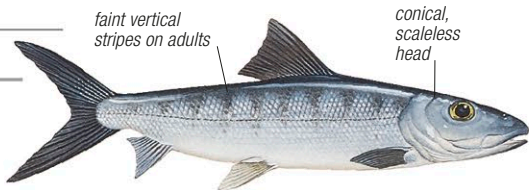
Length 3¼ ft (Up to 1 m)
Weight 20 lb (9 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Near threatened

Location Atlantic



Found in shallow, coastal marine habitats, typically over mud flats and mangrove lagoons, the bonefish is more important as

a sport fish than as food. Like tarpon, it can survive in low-oxygen water by gulping air. It feeds on a rising tide, working its way to the muddy bottom with its head down and tail up, blowing jets of water to uncover its prey—usually clams, crabs, and shrimps. Its large size affords it some protection from predators.



Anguilla anguilla

European eel



Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight 10 lb (4.5 kg), max 29 lb (13 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Critically endangered

Location E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Europe



This eel has a remarkable life history. Adults are believed to spawn in the area of the Sargasso Sea, the larvae being transported over a period of 2½ years to European coastal waters by ocean currents. There, they metamorphose into cylindrical, unpigmented “glass eels” before entering rivers in their millions, as silvery, pigmented juveniles called “elvers.” The freshwater stage is a feeding and growing phase; as the eel matures sexually, it descends toward the sea. Mature “silver eels” undertake their spawning migration usually from late summer to winter and mainly on dark, moonless, stormy nights. At this stage, the eyes enlarge, the snout becomes more narrow and pointed, and the pectoral fins more

OUT OF WATER



European eels can survive out of water for several hours in damp, cool conditions. Adults usually travel overland on rainy nights, when the darkness gives them some protection from attack.

lance-shaped—changes that are adaptations to the ocean's depths. Once an extremely common fish, the European eel has declined dramatically in recent decades. Pollution, dams, and overfishing are serious threats, together with climate change.

ADULT COLORATION

In its freshwater stage, this fish has a yellowish or even golden underside. As it approaches sexual maturity, it becomes silvery below and almost black above (as shown here).



size. An aggressive fish, it is known to defend its territory strongly against intruders. Some morays, although not necessarily this species, are noted for the presence of toxins on their skin.

